SP. But the real credit for the Congress's strong performance in 2009 should have gone to the prime minister. Only a year before, he had dared the left parties to withdraw support to his government over the Indo-US nuclear deal, stitched an alliance with the SP and won a contentious vote on the nuclear issue in Parliament. Indians like it when their leaders get tough—the nuclear vote, no matter how briefly, transformed Dr Singh into a prime minister who was ready to sacrifice his chair for a principle. 'Singh is King' became the theme song that carried the UPA to victory. The BJP's L.K. Advani, by contrast, looked liked a tired leader, well past his prime. Yet, the self-effacing prime minister was forgotten and Rahul was hailed as the game changer.

The CNN-IBN Indian of the Year awards were held in December that year. The prime minister was the chief guest, Rahul one of the winners. Every other winner—be it A.R. Rahman (who was chosen as the overall Indian of the Year for his Oscar-winning compositions in *Slumdog Millionaire*) or badminton player Saina Nehwal who won the award for sports—was present at the ceremony. Rahul chose not to attend. For weeks before the event, we had tried to convince him to receive the award. Several phone calls and emails went typically unanswered. We had even asked his sister Priyanka to remind him that it would appear inappropriate for Rahul to stay away when the prime minister was the chief guest. 'He is very busy, you can read out a message on his behalf,' was the official response from Team Rahul. The fact is, Rahul was in Delhi, but apparently did not see any reason to attend the function. A message was read out on his behalf.

Why did Rahul choose to avoid receiving an award from the prime minister? Priyanka claimed that Rahul didn't believe in awards. 'He likes his work to do the talking,' was her explanation. Maybe Rahul realized what some of us hadn't—he still hadn't done quite enough to deserve the label of 'politician of the year'.

Giving Rahul the major credit for the 2009 victory was not the only misreading of the electoral result. The Congress party believed that the win was a triumph of their 'inclusive' social and economic agenda. The government's flagship scheme for rural jobs—the National Rural